

significance this would have in a future political order based on universal suffrage, he insisted that there should be parity between the communities. For him, this was a point of principle, not a particular claim to territory. In fact, he was remarkably insouciant about the actual territorial specification of his Pakistan idea, and though he called it 'moth-eaten', he was willingly accepted in what was probably the oddest territorial state ever created in modern times, its two halves separated by the vast Indian hinterland ('two wings without a body', as it has been described).

Jinnah sought not purity for Pakistan, but parity: not identity, but equality. Pakistan was founded on the assumption that statehood would ensure such parity for the subcontinent's Muslims. But Pakistan's subsequent history has been a bitter lesson in the fact that not all states are equal. It has made Pakistan perpetually dependent on some external, third party—the UN, the US, China—to intercede on its behalf, to act as an umpire that can ensure its claims will be treated with parity. The fierce obsession of Pakistan's leaders with nuclear weapons ('we shall eat grass...') is rooted in the conviction that these explosives, at least and at last, will give that veto power that Jinnah always sought.

Anyone who studies the tortuous path to 1947 will have his or her favourite 'turning points' when things might have taken a different direction. Jasant has his own list: the 1928 Nehru Report on the Constitution, the Round Table Conferences and the Congress's refusal to engage with them, the refusal to form coalition governments with the Muslim League in Uttar Pradesh in 1937; Congress's rejection of the British offer of Dominion status; the decision, during World War II, by Gandhi and Congress leadership to choose jail, thus leaving the political field profitably open to Jinnah; above all, the haste of everyone. He is particularly critical of Nehru's re-

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fusal to entertain the possibility of the Dominion status which, had it been accepted, may have allowed a transitional period during which Jinnah's trust could be gained, and, more surprisingly, of Nehru's insistence that India needed a strong central state.

One might add that Nehru also shared responsibility for the lack of rapport between himself and Jinnah, a relationship hugely consequential for Indian history. The two men were similar in various respects: both were from marginal, cosmopolitan communities (Khoja Muslim and Kashmiri Pandit), both trained as lawyers, both were Anglicised, fastidious and vain. And both cultivated their dislike for each another. In their letters to one another, Nehru condescended and sermonised while Jinnah resorted to stilted mannerisms: "I reciprocate the sentiments expressed in the last but one paragraph of your letter at the end of it." To Nehru's lectures, Jinnah could only reply, "You prefer talking at each other whereas I prefer talking to each other." Crucially, in the run-up to Partition, Nehru was unable to fully grasp the irreducible fear that many Muslims felt, and that Jinnah voiced—fear at the prospect of having to live as a minority within a democratic regime where political power was based on numerical strength. (That Nehru, after Partition, made up for this earlier failure by his many efforts to assure Muslims of their place as full citizens of the Republic, is a vital part of any assessment of Nehru.)

Might things have turned out otherwise if, for instance, the Jinnah-Nehru relationship had been different? In history, in so far as it is an account of human actions, things might have turned out differently; and very often we like to rest those possibilities upon the choices or character of an individual. But in considering the volatile decades between 1920 and 1950, it's striking how many crucial events were not intended by the leading individual actors, how sheerly contingent they were.

The human mind is accustomed to assigning blame and responsibility, and it is difficult to accept that something like the Partition, which produced such momentous consequences, might, in fact, have been only weakly intended. We wish to find monsters at the origin of terrible events. Yet part of what makes such events so terrible is less that they arose from malign individual motives, but that they happened largely despite the intentions of the leading actors.

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